Antigone

By Sophocles (Translated by R.C. Jebb)

INTRODUCTION

A great battle has ended over dominion of the ancient city of Thebes. Massive causalities are incurred by both the insurgents and those soldiers defending their King. Two brothers die; one given a hero's burial; the other, by royal edict, will receive no burial . . . but will instead be left as he fell . . . food for carrion. The law of man has spoken . . . but one young girl refuses to governed by the blasphemous laws of man: Antigone by Sophocles.

ANTIGONE
Ismene, sister, mine own dear sister, knowest thou what ill there is, of all bequeathed by Oedipus, that Zeus fulfils not for us twain while we live? Nothing painful is there, nothing fraught with ruin, no shame, no dishonour, that I have not seen in thy woes and mine.

And now what new edict is this of which they tell, that our Captain hath just published to all Thebes? Knowest thou aught? Hast thou heard? Or is it hidden from thee that our friends are threatened with the doom of our foes?

ISMENE
No word of friends, Antigone, gladsome or painful, hath come to me, since we two sisters were bereft of brothers twain, killed in one day by twofold blow; and since in this last night the Argive host hath fled, know no more, whether my fortune be brighter, or more grievous.

ANTIGONE
I knew it well, and therefore sought to bring thee beyond the gates of the court, that thou mightest hear alone.

ISMENE
What is it? 'Tis plain that thou art brooding on some dark tidings.

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ANTIGONE
What, hath not Creon destined our brothers, the one to honoured burial, the other to unburied shame? Eteocles, they say, with due observance of right and custom, he hath laid in the earth, for his honour among the dead below. But the hapless corpse of Polyneices-as rumour saith, it hath been published to the town that none shall entomb him or mourn, but leave unwept, a welcome store for the birds, as they espy him, to feast on at will.

ISMENE
Poor sister,-and if things stand thus, what could I help to do or undo?

ANTIGONE
Consider if thou wilt share the toil and the deed. Wilt thou aid this hand to lift the dead?

ISMENE
Thou wouldst bury him,-when 'tis forbidden to Thebes? Ah, over-bold! when Creon hath forbidden?

ANTIGONE
Nay, he hath no right to keep me from mine own.

ISMENE
Ah me! think, sister, how our father perished, amid hate and scorn, when sins bared by his own search had moved him to strike both eyes with self-blinding hand; then the mother wife, two names in one, with twisted noose did despite unto her life; and last, our two brothers in one day,-each shedding, hapless one, a kinsman's blood,-wrought out with mutual hands their common doom. And now we in turn-we two left all alone think how we shall perish, more miserably than all the rest, if, in defiance of the law, we brave a king's decree or his powers. Nay, we must remember, first, that we were born women, as who should not strive with men; next, that we are ruled of the stronger, so that we must obey in these things.

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ANTIGONE
Nay, be what thou wilt; but I will bury him: well for me to die in doing that. I owe a longer allegiance to the dead than to the living: in that world I shall abide for ever. But if thou wilt, be guilty of dishonouring laws which the gods have stablished in honour.

ISMENE
I do them no dishonour; but to defy the State,-I have no strength for that. A hopeless quest should not be made at all.

ANTIGONE
If thus thou speakest, thou wilt have hatred from me, and will justly be subject to the lasting hatred of the dead. Leave me, and the folly that is mine alone, to suffer this dread thing; for I shall not suffer aught so dreadful as an ignoble death.

TRANSITION

And so Antigone. . . alone. . . bears the honor and the burden of burying her beloved brother, Polyneices. For her disobedience she will face the wrath of King Creon. . . again . . . alone. Silence descends as Antigone is brought before the King, the dirt from her brother's grave still fresh upon her hands.

CREON
Thou-thou whose face is bent to earth-dost thou avow, or disavow, this deed?

ANTIGONE
I avow it; I make no denial.

CREON
Now, tell me thou-not in many words, but briefly-knewest thou that an edict had forbidden this?

ANTIGONE
I knew it: could I help it? It was public.

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CREON
And thou didst indeed dare to transgress that law?

ANTIGONE
Yes; for it was not Zeus that had published me that edict; not such are the laws set among men by the justice who dwells with the gods below; nor deemed I that thy decrees were of such force, that a mortal could override the unwritten and unfailing statutes of heaven. For their life is not of to-day or yesterday, but from all time, and no man knows when they were first put forth.

Not through dread of any human pride could I answer to the gods for breaking these. Die I must,-I knew that well (how should I not?)-even without thy edicts. But if I am to die before my time, I count that a gain: for when any one lives, as I do, compassed about with evils, can such an one find aught but gain in death?

So for me to meet this doom is trifling grief; but if I had suffered my mother's son to lie in death an unburied corpse, that would have grieved me; for this, I am not grieved. And if my present deeds are foolish in thy sight, it may be that a foolish judge arraigns my folly.

CREON
Yet I would have thee know that o'er-stubborn spirits are most often humbled; 'tis the stiffest iron, baked to hardness in the fire, that thou shalt oftenest see snapped and shivered; and I have known horses that show temper brought to order by a little curb; there is no room for pride when thou art thy neighbour's slave. So oft, before the deed, the mind stands self-convicted in its treason, when folks are plotting mischief in the dark. But verily this, too, is hateful,-when one who hath been caught in wickedness then seeks to make the crime a glory.

ANTIGONE
Wouldst thou do more than take and slay me?

CREON
No more, indeed; having that, I have all.

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ANTIGONE
Why then dost thou delay? In thy discourse there is nought that pleases me,-never may there be!-and so my words must needs be unpleasing to thee. And yet, for glory-whence could I have won a nobler, than by giving burial to mine own brother? All here would own that they thought it well, were not their lips sealed by fear. But royalty, blest in so much besides, hath the power to do and say what it will.

CREON
Was it not a brother, too, that died in the opposite cause?

ANTIGONE
Brother by the same mother and the same sire.

CREON
And yet thou makest him but equal in honour with the wicked.

ANTIGONE
It was his brother, not his slave, that perished.

CREON
But the good desires not a like portion with the evil.

ANTIGONE
Tis not my nature to join in hating, but in loving.

CREON to Antigone
Pass, then, to the world of the dead, and, it thou must needs love, love them. While I live, no woman shall rule me . . .

CREON thinks
I will take her where the path is loneliest, and hide her, living, in rocky vault, with so much food set forth as piety prescribes, that the city may avoid a public stain. And there, praying to Hades, the only god whom she worships, perchance she will obtain release from death; or else will learn, at last, though late, that it is lost labour to revere the dead.

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CREON to Antigone
Know ye not that songs and wailings before death would never cease, if it profited to utter them? Away with her-away! And when ye have enclosed her, according to my word, in her vaulted grave, leave her alone, forlorn-whether she wishes to die, or to live a buried life in such a home. Our hands are clean as touching this maiden. But this is certain-she shall be deprived of her sojourn in the light.

ANTIGONE
Tomb, bridal-chamber, eternal prison in the caverned rock, whither go to find mine own, those many who have perished, and whom Persephone hath received among the dead! Last of all shall I pass thither, and far most miserably of all, before the term of my life is spent. But I cherish good hope that my coming will be welcome to my father, and pleasant to thee, my mother, and welcome, brother, to thee; for, when ye died, with mine own hands I washed and dressed you, and poured drink-offerings at your graves; and now, Polyneices, 'tis for tending thy corpse that I win such recompense as this.

And yet I honoured thee, as the wise will deem, rightly. Such was the law whereby I held thee first in honour; but Creon deemed me guilty of error therein, and of outrage, ah brother mine! And now he leads me thus, a captive in his hands; no bridal bed, no bridal song hath been mine, no joy of marriage, no portion in the nurture of children; but thus, forlorn of friends, unhappy one, I go living to the vaults of death.

And what law of heaven have I transgressed? Why, hapless one, should I look to the gods any more,-what ally should I invoke,-when by piety I have earned the name of impious? Nay, then, if these things are pleasing to the gods, when I have suffered my doom, I shall come to know my sin; but if the sin is with my judges, I could wish them no fuller measure of evil than they, on their part, mete wrongfully to me.

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AWARDS

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